

You can stop individual providers from the icon in the system tray: avast! has what it calls ‘providers’, which is basically the different parts of the program that scan for different things—IMs, P2P, Web, e-mail, and so on. The configuration screen can be configured to show little detail or more detail. In other words, you can either let the program do its work without knowing what it’s doing—accepting what avast! thinks is optimal—or you can get your hands dirty and mess around with the settings if you wish.

Coming to the scanner program: you can choose, amongst other things, the type of scan: quick, standard, or thorough. But there’s something quirky we must mention here: the interface has a cool blue look, with a ‘play’ button for starting a scan and so on—and it’s actually skinnable! It looks a little like Winamp or some other media player, with cool buttons and so forth. Now who would ever want to download and place a skin on an anti-virus program? But well, there it is!

Finally, avast! is *very* light on system resources—which is important for anyone who has a slightly older computer! The only time it uses system resources is when it’s updating. Also, there’s a good support forum, at, of course, <http://forum.avast.com/>.

Avast!’s VRDB

VRDB stands for ‘Virus Recovery Database.’ The aim of the VRDB is to help when, despite all the security measures, a virus gets inside the computer and files get infected. With the help of the VRDB, it is possible to repair infected files (return them exactly to their original state).

avast! stores information about the actual state of the files, doing it three versions back for each file. The database creation/maintenance is performed either when the computer is idle, or when the screen saver is running. You can choose when this gets done. This database, once it is created, is updated every three weeks—this value may be changed by editing the ‘avast4.ini’ file.